

MADHYASTH DARSHAN IN DIALOGUE · §§2–7

Coexistence in Comparison

*Advaita Vedānta · Contemporary Philosophy · Empirical
Science*

A criterion-by-criterion comparison of ontology, evidence, value, and open questions

Companion to The Ontology of Coexistence · revised July 2026





METHOD · §§5.1, 5.3.5

Compare answers at the same level

Each view is first stated in its own vocabulary. Darshanas join ontology, knowledge, liberation, and conduct; philosophical theories isolate particular problems; science supplies empirically constrained models that admit more than one metaphysical interpretation.

Own terms first

Do not force a darshana, a metaphysical theory, and an empirical model into the same explanatory role.

Ten common criteria

Compare primitives, individuation, dependence, world, change, self, time, evidence, value, and correction.

Four forms of warrant

Keep logical grounding, first-person verification, conduct-evidence, and instrument-based confirmation distinct.

Structured comparison: no single method settles every claim, but each view can be tested for coherence, source fidelity, explanatory reach, and fit with public knowledge.



Advaita: robust world, dependent being

Advaita holds Brahman alone to be absolute reality. The empirical world is shared, law-governed, ethically serious, and indispensable to liberation; it is mithya because it has no independent being at paramartha.

Tier	What is presented?	Status and sublation
Apparent (pratibhasika)	Private error, dream, misperception	Sublated by correction or waking
Empirical (vyavahara)	Bodies, minds, Ishvara, causes, duties, science	Shared and operationally valid; sublated by brahma-jnana
Absolute (paramartha)	Brahman without a second	Name-form has no independent being

Sat–Chit–Ananda names one partless Brahman. The three tiers explain private error, shared experience, and non-dual realisation without reducing vyavahara to hallucination.



Advaita's causal and epistemic structure

Effect–cause non-difference

The effect has no being apart from its cause. Later Advaita calls name-form on changeless Brahman vivarta—not a second real transformation.

Maya and adhyasa

Later accounts speak of concealment and projection; Shankara's load-bearing claim is superimposition and the dependent status of name-form.

Witness-consciousness

Seer–seen discrimination and three-state analysis disclose non-objectifiable awareness, finally Brahman rather than an individual substance.

Liberation and conduct

Shabda, reasoning, and contemplation remove ignorance. Dharma and loka-sangraha remain meaningful expressions of knowledge in embodied life.



Physicalism is one family—not science

Physicalist positions share physical dependence, but differ over reduction, functional role, higher-level organisation, and causal powers. Causal closure pressures a distinct jeevan; the hard problem pressures reductive sufficiency.

The explanatory fork: brain–experience correlation is secure, yet why processing is accompanied by subjectivity remains disputed. That gap is neither proof of jeevan nor proof that matter-only explanation will succeed.

Reductive and identity views

Mental phenomena are identical with, or reducible to, physical states and processes.

Functional and non-reductive views

Mental states are individuated by role or higher-level organisation while remaining physically dependent.

Emergent and eliminative replies

Emergence posits novel organisation or powers; illusionism redescribes phenomenal reports rather than adding a separate bearer.



Modern alternatives: partial analogies

Approach	Partial analogy with MD	Decisive divergence
Hylomorphism	Living body as a matter–form compound; joint embodiment	No co-eternal satta–unit saturation or jeevan atom
Spinoza	Pervasive ground and finite modes	Modes are not co-eternal units on a par with substance
Leibniz	Plural, persisting individual centres	Windowless monads; harmony is divinely pre-established
Process philosophy	Relations and becoming are fundamental	Occasions perish; no permanent jeevan individual
Panpsychism / neutral monism	Rejects a simple matter-only intrinsic nature	Experience or neutral reality is distributed or constitutive, not MD's threshold

Each view illuminates one MD commitment while differing on ground, individuation, persistence, or the bearer of experience.



Science maps function, not full ontology

Self-models and predictive processing

Neural and embodied models explain ownership, perspective, prediction, and regulation. They show dependence of measurable personal capacities on living organisation.

Consciousness programmes

IIT, global-workspace, recurrent-processing, higher-order, and predictive approaches expose different mechanisms and predictions; no programme has settled the bearer question.

Brain death and continuity

Accepted criteria mark irreversible loss of measurable organismal and personal function. No public post-death continuity has been established.

What remains metaphysical

Mechanisms constrain MD but do not by themselves decide whether organismal continuity exhausts the subject of experience.



Science constrains; it does not confirm

Did existence begin?

Λ CDM reconstructs a hot dense early universe, not necessarily an absolute beginning. Bounce, cyclic, and inflationary models remain competing programmes—not proof of jagat satat.

What persists?

QFT tracks fields, excitations, symmetries, and conserved quantities. Transformation without everyday annihilation is a parallel, but fields are not bounded ikai and satta is not a dynamical field.

Discipline of comparison: use ‘parallel to,’ ‘consonant with,’ or ‘in tension with’ unless a shared operational criterion has been established.

Niyati-kram and evolution work at different descriptive levels. The open task is to map MD’s ordered relations to descent, variation, selection, drift, development, and contingency.



Ten criteria prevent false alliances

1–2

Primitives and individuation
What is fundamental, and what makes one being distinct?

3

Ground and particulars
Does the ground produce, constitute, sustain, or sublate particulars?

4–5

World and change
What remains real, and what persists or transforms?

6

Self and survival
What bears experience, and does it persist?

7–8

Time and evidence
How is history understood, and how are claims warranted?

9–10

Value and correction
Is purpose real, and what could revise the view?



Ground, self, and matter divide the views

Aspect	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Contemporary metaphysics
Fundamental	Omnipresence plus real units	Brahman alone at paramartha	Physical, experiential, neutral, form–matter, or process primitives
Individuation	Bounded units; jeevan permanently distinct	Individuality conditioned; true Self is Brahman	Organism, continuity, soul-form, monad, subject, or process
Sentient bearer	Constitutionally complete jeevan	Atman is non-dual Brahman	Physical organisation or a rival non-reductive bearer
Matter and body	Real jada units compose jeevan’s instrument	Name-form valid at vyavahara	Mind-independent physical or embodied organisation
Survival	Yes, grounded in gathanpurnata	Not as a separate individual	Generally no; some soul-form or monadic views allow persistence
Ground relation	Saturation, not production	Effect has no being apart from Brahman	Reduction, constitution, grounding, modes, or process



What finally persists divides the views

Aspect	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Contemporary metaphysics
World status	Perpetual; retains final ontological weight	Robust at vyavahara; no independent being at paramartha	Realism, idealism, structuralism, and instrumentalism vary
Change	Real transformation of units; satta actionless	Effect–cause non-difference and vivarta	Dynamics, emergence, process, or form–matter change
Causation	Sustaining mahakaran; units act in mutuality	Causal teaching at vyavahara	Laws, constraints, mechanisms, probabilities, or higher-level causes
Beginning	No existence from abhava; configurations change	Brahman beginningless; empirical cycles	Cosmic history and absolute beginning receive different answers
Time	Duration of unit-activity; satta timeless	Valid at vyavahara; Brahman timeless	Eternalist, presentist, relational, and process accounts
Value and telos	Values structural; humane conduct evidences awakening	Dharma and loka-sangraha; moksha through knowledge	Ontology alone does not fix ethics; naturalisms and realisms compete

Empirical science reconstructs histories through dynamics, probabilities, boundary conditions, mechanisms, and selection; it does not by itself choose one complete metaphysics.



Methods expose different kinds of claim

View	Principal method	Claimed reach	Exposed boundary
Madhyasth Darshan	Study → experiment/practice → realisation → conduct	Coexistence, jeevan, humane order	Needs public criteria for gathanpurnata and persistence
Advaita Vedanta	Shabda, reasoning, contemplative discrimination	Non-dual identity; removal of superimposition	Authority and sublation criteria are not shared
Contemporary philosophy	Argument, phenomenology, explanatory comparison	Coherence and comparative plausibility	Persistent disagreement; few decisive tests

Empirical science: observation, instrumentation, modelling, intervention, replication, and criticism establish public mechanisms and constraints—not a complete metaphysics or ultimate value.

Comparison remains possible when each claim states its method, reach, and what could count against it.



Sat–Chit–Ananda: one term, two structures

Concept	Advaita Vedanta	Madhyasth Darshan
Sat (being)	Brahman alone is absolute being; world is dependent, not sheer nothing	Astitva is coexistence of Omnipresence and countless real units
Chit (awareness)	Brahman is self-luminous awareness; the Self is not an object	Omnipresence is intelligibility-ground; active sentience belongs to jeevan
Ananda (fullness / bliss)	Intrinsic limitlessness and fullness of Brahman	Realised harmony in awakened jeevan, evidenced in conduct

Limited alignment: neither view reduces the knower to an observed brain-state. The decisive divergence is one impersonal Self versus many permanently distinct jeevan units.



Analogy is not ontological equivalence

Limited structural analogies

- Brahman / satta — both are described as formless and non-transforming, but their one-many structures differ
- Witness inquiry / jeevan inquiry — the knower is not exhausted by the gross body
- Jiva / deluded jeevan — embodied ignorance is practically central, but individuality has different status
- Jagat / nature — the changing world is the field of duty and inquiry

Categories that do not transfer

- Atman ≠ atma — Advaita's Self is Brahman; MD's atma is a faculty within jeevan
- Maya / adhyasa — MD has no cosmic projection or ontological superimposition
- Mithya — MD retains final reality of units and relationships
- Ishvara — MD's satta is actionless, not a governing maker
- Moksha / kaivalya — MD awakening preserves distinct jeevan



The open task is an evidential bridge

These are pressures of public identification and comparison, not missing primary-text doctrine.

6.2.1 • Identify completeness

What observation would distinguish a closed, weight-free, hope-bound jeevan constitution from known physical and chemical organisation?

6.2.2 • Test persistence

What evidence could distinguish jeevan—body joint operation, post-death continuity, or reassociation from a brain-only account?

6.2.3 • Separate evidence levels

Keep logical, first-person, conduct, and instrument evidence distinct; map niyati-kram to evolutionary explanation without declaring a direct contradiction.

MD's own case rests on constitutional completeness—not generic conservation. The unanswered question is independent identification and testing.



Rivals impose different constraints

View	Strengths	Exposed limit	What remains genuinely at issue
Advaita Vedanta	Non-being argument; disciplined first-person method; ontological parsimony	Final weight of world, relationships, and individuality	Its reply is coherent; the disagreement concerns sublation
Physicalist family	Mechanism, causal discipline, continuity with public science	Hard problem; no single settled theory of self or consciousness	An explanatory gap neither proves jeevan nor settles matter-only
Empirical science	Public measurement, correction, history, and brain-dependence	Does not alone choose complete metaphysics or ultimate value	Operational evidence remains a decisive constraint on MD

No single modern front opposes MD: Advaita, physicalist theories, and empirical science test different commitments.

The comparison is strongest when each rival's achievement is granted before its exposed limit is named.



Coherence does not remove evidence duties

Focus	Internal strength	Open obligation	Productive next step
MD ontology	One two-term picture keeps world, self, value, and relations real	Complexity and stronger claims require independent warrant	State discriminating consequences
Constitutional completeness	A definite primary-text threshold—not biological emergence	No public identifier in current physical terms	Specify measurable or method-specific criteria
Persistence and evolution	Gathanpurnata grounds survival within MD; order levels are distinct	Reassociation and niyati mapping remain unconfirmed	Compare neuroscience and evolution without category conflation

Conduct-evidence is substantial practical evidence; it is not yet a physical detector for jeevan.

Further work should state what could discriminate MD's stronger claims from rival explanations.

WHAT THE COMPARISON ESTABLISHES

Limited alignments, one open bridge



MD's distinctive result

Coexistence retains formless Omnipresence and countless real units; change belongs to units, jeevan remains distinct, and world, relationships, and values retain final weight.

Question-specific alignments

With scientific realism on mind-independent nature; with Advaita against reductive accounts of the knower; with modern alternatives against a simple substance inventory.

“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.” — MVD, p. 13

What remains open: public identification of constitutional completeness; independent evidence for jeevan's persistence and joint operation; and a clearer separation of evidence levels with an evolutionary mapping. Science constrains the bridge—it is not physicalism, and no stable alliance follows.